

BODY FIRST FRAMEWORK®
Manual and
Toolkit



For professionals helping clients regulate
emotions and behavior

Dr. Caelan Soma



Welcome to the Body First Framework

I know what it's like to sit in that chair. You're working with a client who is dysregulated or a family who is completely tapped out. They've tried coping skills, positive rewards, and "time-outs," but everything seems to add fuel to the fire. As therapists, we have the science and we know it's about the nervous system, but translating that into a Tuesday night meltdown is where things get tricky.

I've spent my career trying to bridge that gap. I've authored books, built curricula, and presented to thousands of professionals, but some of my most important work has happened in the quiet, messy moments of clinical practice.

I created the Body First Framework because I realized that clients don't need more theory, they need to know exactly what to do when they feel like they're guessing (or second-guessing) themselves.

My hope is that you can integrate the components in this manual and toolkit into your own practice with clients and families.



Who is this approach for?

The Body First Framework is especially helpful when working with a client/family who:

- is dysregulated, has big emotions, frequent meltdowns and outbursts
- becomes easily overwhelmed or shuts down
- struggles with anger, frustration, or impulsive behavior
- has difficulty recovering after disappointment or conflict
- seems defiant or oppositional when stressed
- has a hard time transitioning between activities
- becomes emotionally reactive at home but holds it together at school/work
- is affected by anxiety, stress, trauma, or sensory overwhelm

Principles apply from early childhood through adulthood

- young children learning early emotional regulation and how to feel safe in their bodies
- school-age children struggling with frustration, big emotions, or behavior challenges
- preteens navigating social stress, growing awareness, and identity development
- teenagers dealing with anxiety, pressure, and intense emotional experiences
- young adults finding their footing through change, relationships, and the stress of early adult life
- adults working through anxiety, trauma, burnout, and patterns that no longer feel sustainable



About the Framework

A nest is made of many different pieces, twigs, mud, grass - all woven together to create strength.

Regulation isn't one single "trick." It's the combination of spotting stress signals, regulating daily, and consistent self-care.

A nest isn't just a home; it's a carefully constructed environment designed for one specific purpose: safety. Before a bird can learn to fly, it must be held.

We aren't starting with behaviors (the flight or fight); we are starting with the environment of the body and the home (the nest). If the nest is unstable, the "egg" (a developing or nervous system that is re-wiring) cannot thrive)

Each "twig" in the framework represents a different practical tool that, when woven together, creates a structure strong enough to hold a client through an emotional storm.

When a client is overwhelmed, they feel "uncontained." Their emotions are spilling out everywhere.

The nest symbolizes our role as the "container." By using the Body First approach, we are strengthening our capacity to hold big emotions without the nest breaking. It's about being sturdy and reliable so the client can do the hard work of practicing regulation.

Inside every "challenging emotions or behavior" is a vulnerable nervous system trying to protect itself. The nest reminds parents and therapists that our first job is to protect that vulnerability through regulation, rather than attacking the behavior with words and consequences.

Nests are built one piece at a time. They require maintenance.

This isn't about being perfect. It's about the daily act of placing one more twig of connection or one more leaf of regulation.

.



The Body First Framework grew out of a desire to translate neuroscience, trauma-informed care, and attachment research into clear, practical tools that clients can use in everyday life.

At its core, the goal of this framework is simple: to help respond to clients in ways that build safety, connection, and lifelong emotional skills.



Body First Framework Steps

01

START WITH THE BODY

- Emotions are body responses
- The nervous system sends signals before behavior
- Logic fails during overwhelm

02

SPOT STRESS SIGNALS EARLY

- Stress signals might be quiet or loud
- When you notice, you can respond (sooner)
- Settling the body is the goal

03

CALM EMOTIONAL STORMS

- Co-regulation settles stress responses
- Presence alone is calming
- Co-regulation is a must before self-regulation

04

TEACH SKILLS

- Stressed brains can't learn
- Body awareness matters
- Repetition is required

05

REGULATE DAILY

- Predictability creates safety
- Structure is found in routines
- Don't forget basic needs

06

REPAIR AND RECONNECT

- Strengthen relationships after hard moments
- Repairs regulate
- Ruptures are normal

07

SELF CARE

- Identify quick resets
- Predict and make a plan

01 Start with the body

Big feelings don't start as behavior. They start in the body. Before yelling, crying, or shutdown, our nervous system is already working overtime to handle stress.

What looks like "overreacting" is usually a body that feels overwhelmed and unsafe.

An emotional or behavioral outburst isn't misbehavior – it's nervous system overload. When the body goes into stress mode, thinking skills go offline. This is not a choice to fall apart, it is a system is doing its best to cope with more than it can handle.

That's why the first step is not talking, lecturing or teaching.
The first step is helping the body feel safe.



Step 1

Start with the Body

The body leads - the brain follows.

LESSONS

- Felt Safety
- Basic Needs
- Body Sensations

Remember This!

START WITH THE BODY: SETTLE FIRST, TALK LATER

- Emotions are body responses
- The nervous system sends signals before behavior
- Logic fails during overwhelm

Felt Safety

Step 1 Start with the Body

Lesson: Felt Safety

Goal

Shift the focus from fixing behavior to supporting the nervous system.

Education and Shift

We can't "behave" or "learn" if our nervous system detects threat. Behavior and emotions are the result of our internal state.

Instead of "Why are they doing like this? Ask, "What is their nervous system experiencing right now?"

Address the body first.

Scripts for Connection

"We are not ignoring behavior, we are just changing the order of how we handle it. Once we calm the body, the brain can listen."

"I can see your body is having a hard time right now. I am going to stay right here until it feels a bit quieter."

"Let's settle your system first, then we can talk."

Body Battery Check

Invite the client to sit down in a "nest" of pillows or in a cozy space. Ask them to take 3 deep breaths. Then ask, "Is your body feeling low and tired or is it "zipping or overcharged?"

Weekly Practice

Once per day during a calm moment, ask check in with yourself/your child, "Where in your body feels the most relaxed right now? Your toes, tummy, etc."

Mantra:

Connection before correction

Therapist Note

During the session observe body language. If rigid or leaning in aggressively, the client's body might remain in "threat" mode. Encourage taking a deep breath and softening shoulders.

Basic Needs

Step 1 Start with the Body

Lesson: Basic Needs

Goal To ensure the "Internal Nest" is physically supported by meeting basic physiological needs.

Education and Shift

A hungry, thirsty, or exhausted brain cannot access the higher-level functions needed for regulation. We must stabilize the "biological baseline" first.

Shift from "Volatile emotions or bad behavior" to "The fuel tank is empty."

Scripts for Connection

"When basic needs are not met, our nervous system registers 'stress.'"

"Your engine seems to be running a bit fast. Let's have a big glass of water and a crunchy snack before we talk about what happened.

Or, "Let's take a few deep breaths together before we start our session."

HALTS visual

Create a visual chart Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired, Stressed. Put the chart somewhere visible as a reminder to meet basic needs.

Weekly Practice

Implement a "Transition Snack"—a consistent, protein-rich snack offered before transitions to prevent blood sugar crashes.

Mantra:

Biology before Behavior

Therapist Note

Focus on the "Predictable Rhythm." Inconsistency in sleep or meals often manifests as "unpredictable" behavioral or emotional outbursts.

02

Spot stress signals early



66 *All behavior has a build-up*

Emotional storms rarely come out of nowhere.

They build quietly.

Small changes in your mood, energy, or behavior are often early warning signs that stress is rising. When you catch these signals early, you can step in before emotions spill over into outbursts or shutdowns.

Think of it like noticing dark clouds before a thunderstorm.

Early support is easier, gentler, and more effective.

Body Clues Cheat Sheet

Signs your client's nervous system is overwhelmed

Fast & Loud Clues

- Yelling or screaming
- Crying quickly
- Clenched fists or jaw
- Pacing or restless movement
- Arguing over small things

Quiet & Shut-Down Clues

- Zoning out
- Refusing to talk
- Hiding or avoiding
- Going limp or slumping
- Saying "I don't care"

Early Stress Signals

- Sudden silliness or hyperactivity
- Irritability
- Complaining about small discomforts
- Trouble with transitions
- Becoming unusually clingy

What to do

1

Pause before responding. Your calm body helps their calm body.

2

Lower your voice and slow your movements. A softer presence signals safety. Use fewer words

3

Move closer (if they accept comfort). Connection regulates the nervous system.

4

Focus on settling, not on solving.

What NOT to Say

"Calm down right now."

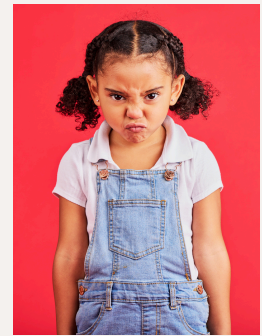
"Stop being dramatic."

"You're fine."

"Why are you acting like this?"

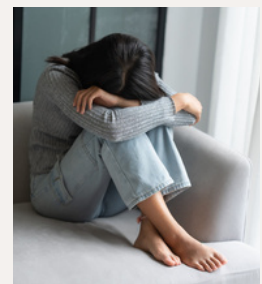
Early warning signs

- Getting frustrated faster than usual
- Arguing or saying “no” to simple requests
- Becoming unusually silly or hyper
- Complaining about minor discomforts
- Avoiding tasks they can usually handle
- Increased clinginess
- Trouble with transitions
- Changes in tone, posture, or facial expression



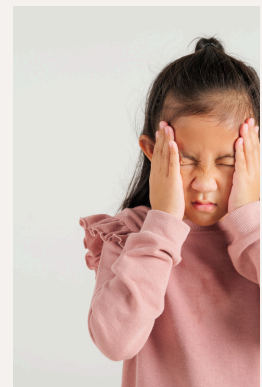
Quick wins that make a difference

- Meet physical needs: offer water, snack or movement
- Reduce demands and lower expectations
- Increase connection: Sit nearby, gentle touch
- Name what you notice: “You’re having a hard time.”



Why this matters

Catching stress early helps your client stay within a manageable emotional range. It prevents nervous system overload and teaches them that support is available before things feel out of control.



You're not just preventing outbursts, you're teaching regulation skills for life.